

ARMY OFFICER AND POLITICIAN 1913–85

GENERAL LON NOL

Lon Nol served in the French colonial service from 1937 and entered the police force in 1951. He joined the army in 1952, taking part in the fight against Vietnamese communist insurgents. In 1960, he became commander in chief of the Cambodian army. Subsequently, he held the posts of defense minister and prime minister, alternately or simultaneously. Following the overthrow of Sihanouk in March 1970, and despite a debilitating stroke in 1971, he led the government in Phnom Penh until March 1975, when he left Cambodia.



» AFTER

General Lon Nol failed to halt the activities of communist forces—both from Cambodia and Vietnam—in spite of military support from the United States.

INCURSION AND RETREAT

In April 1970, US forces launched a **massive incursion** of 252–53 of ground forces into Cambodian territory with the aim of disrupting communist networks in the country. This produced such a **storm of domestic protests** in the United States that the administration had to retreat.

SUPPORT WITHDRAWN

This experience left the United States reluctant to commit to further action on the ground, leaving the weak government of Lon Nol **unable to resist** the ever-increasing strength of the Khmer Rouge.